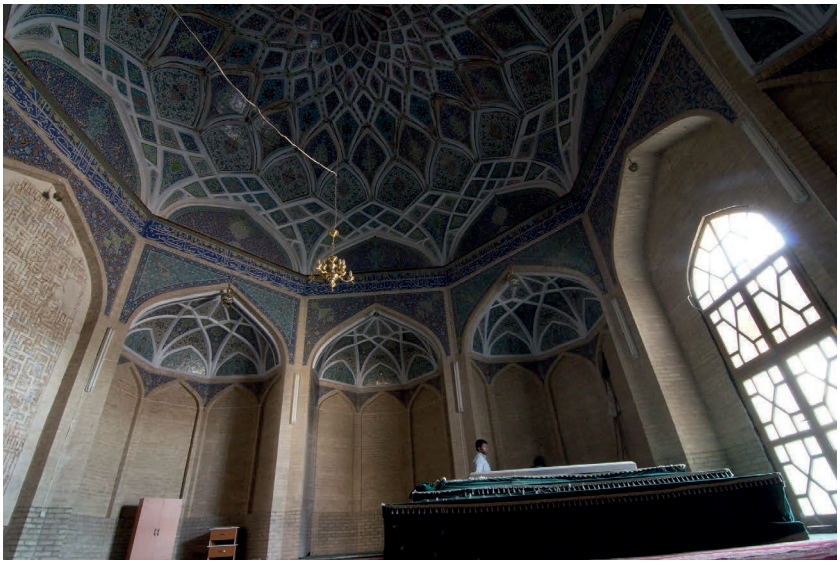


Figure I.15 *Tomb of Ghiyath al-Din Muhammad ibn Sam, Herat, reconstructed* c. *1940s.* © *Photograph Alka Patel 2011.*

any region or polity of nearly one thousand years before the present. But while Shansabani ascendancy was temporally brief, it was geographically and culturally vast, spanning the nomad–urban continuum of central Afghanistan (described below), along with the cosmopolitan emporia of Khurasan to the west; and to the east, the multi-confessional landscapes of the Indus's alluvia, and reaching beyond to the equally variegated north Indian *duab*.

With the Shansabanis' victories in northern India during the 1190s, a qualitative temporal and spatial divide seemed to crystallize between their western and eastern territorial presences, especially in light of the varyingly constituted histories and historiographies of these regions – and indeed those of the eastern Islamic world and South Asia overall. And yet, these regions were ultimately intertwined. The two-volume framework here allows for the analysis of their material and discursive archives separately, but necessarily in dialogue, each with the merited analytical focus. This volume (Volume I) concentrates on the areas now encompassed within modern Afghanistan and Pakistan, spanning the early twelfth century through *c*. 1190 CE. It thereby prepares the way for Volume II, which examines the Shansabanis' extremely consequential expansion into the Indo-Gangetic plains (*c*. 1192–1205 CE), and also traces the *westward* reverberations of the Shansabanis' politico-military successes. Volume II thus closes the cultural–geographical circle, creating a fuller picture of their short-lived but historically significant imperium, in other words an *architectural biography*.